his tenure.[119] Though New Delhi is comfortable with using its close relationship with Kabul and the presence of its four consulates as a tool of psychological warfare against Islamabad, it allegedly practiced considerable restraint in using Afghan soil for such activities (despite Pakistan's suspicions).[120] This is because (a) evidence of Indian covert activities from Afghanistan will hurt Afghans more than India, which in turn, would undermine India's strategic aim of supporting Afghanistan in the first place, and (b) such a covert war may get difficult for India to handle without support by powers such as the US, and within the region, Iran.[121]

Though Manmohan Singh's conciliatory regional approach restrained the scale of India's covert actions after 2004, Pakistan's concerns of Indian involvement in exacerbating its domestic fault-lines, to little or large extents, cannot be discarded despite lack of evidence. Detailing the precise nature or scale of India's covert operations in Pakistan and Afghanistan during the post-9/11 era, or a comprehensive history of the Baloch conflict, is beyond the scope of this book. But highlighting aspects of India's covert approach towards the region is critical for the study of India's Afghanistan policy. Having proactively supported the UF in its anti-Taliban endeavours with Russian and Iranian support in the 1990s, it was unlikely that India would abandon effective partisanship under US pressure. Opening its embassy in Kabul in November 2001, against the wishes of US officials, was a small but potent way to demonstrate India's determination to reengage with Afghanistan along partisan lines. Spymaster Sood admits of a growing sense in India that stronger relations with Afghanistan's Pashtun leaders were critical not just to increase India's presence inside Afghanistan but also with Baloch separatists.[122]

Soon after 2002 India began developing its covert infrastructure to develop what Indian officials called their 'Baloch' and 'Pashtun' cards. Afghanistan's intelligence agency, the National Directorate of Security (NDS), then under, then under Mohammad Arif Sarwari, who had an excellent rapport with India since the civil war years, was a strong ally. With Karzai's permission, Arif began dispatching NDS officers for training to India, unlocking new and heightened levels of intelligence cooperation. Arif's successor, Amrullah Saleh, also had a close relationship with Narayanan. Though various (serving and retired) Indian